

predecessor, Eisenhower, had balked at the cost of a long-term manned space program, seeing the Mercury project as an end rather than a beginning. Kennedy was no more enthusiastic about the high price tag, but he was more ready to identify with a bold technological project that would restore America's belief in itself and its international prestige.

On May 25, 1961, Kennedy told Congress: "I believe that this nation should commit itself to achieving the goal, before this decade is out, of landing a man on the Moon and returning him safely to Earth." It was the opinion among some US space experts that, in the time scale laid down, the goal was unlikely to be achieved. But the die was cast.



AMERICAN FIRST
On May 5, 1961, Alan B. Shepard became the first American to enter space. The Redstone launcher (left) was not powerful enough to propel the Freedom 7 Mercury space vehicle into orbit. Shepard rose to a maximum altitude of 116 miles (186km). During his 15-minute flight, the astronaut's facial expressions were monitored by an on-board camera (below left). Shepard splashed down in the ocean and was rescued by a US Marine helicopter (below) which flew him to USS Lake Champlain.



By the time Kennedy made his famous speech to Congress, Americans had already found something to cheer about as the Mercury program produced its first success. On May 5, 1961, astronaut Alan B. Shepard was, with considerable difficulty, shoehorned into the

Freedom 7 Mercury space vehicle on top of a Redstone launcher. There, sitting with his back to the ground facing the sky, barely able to move, he had to wait for four hours as delay followed delay.

This led to an acutely embarrassing problem with his bladder, as no thought had been given to providing a means of urinating in what was planned as a 15-minute mission. At last, approaching 9:30am, the final countdown began. Across America, millions followed the tense moments on television or radio. The Redstone lifted smoothly from its launch pad and rose through the atmosphere. The rocket separated from the capsule and Shepard sailed through space up to an altitude of 116 miles (186km), his voice on the radio link relayed to the nation.

Safe return

After taking an opportunity to experiment with manual control of the spacecraft in pitch, yaw, and roll, so important to pilots who did not want to be reduced to passengers, Shepard made a successful reentry and splashed down in the Atlantic off Bermuda, some 300 miles (480km) from his starting point in Florida.

In some ways, Shepard's quarter-hour loop through space only emphasized how far the Americans lagged behind the Soviets – it could not compare with Gagarin's 108-minute orbital flight. But it also showed how far the United States was ahead of the Soviet Union in the use of mass media. The American side of the space race began as it was to continue – as a television spectacular. It was to be a gripping drama enacted live that would engage the emotions of viewers worldwide, and stand as an ongoing demonstration of the openness of American society.

Both the Americans and the Soviets continued a program of manned flights with their Mercury and Vostok craft over the next two years. Following in Shepard's footsteps with a suborbital flight in July 1961, Virgil Grissom narrowly avoided disaster when his emergency hatch blew off after splashdown. Grissom made a hasty exit

as his cockpit filled with water and survived with a drenching, although the spacecraft sank and was lost. The following month cosmonaut Gherman Titov put the American efforts in perspective by staying in orbit for over 24 hours in Vostok 2 (the Soviets numbered their Vostoks sequentially, while all the Mercury craft were given the number 7).

By 1962 the Americans had at last overcome the many difficulties experienced with the Atlas launcher and were ready to put an astronaut into orbit. On February 20, John Glenn lifted off from the Cape aboard Friendship 7 on top of a perfectly functioning Atlas. This was not to be



INSIDE FRIENDSHIP 7

Compared with a Soviet Vostok capsule, John Glenn's Friendship 7 was crammed with dials and switches – in part a response to the insistence of the Mercury astronauts on exercising as much manual control as possible over their space vehicles.

HEADING INTO ORBIT

The Atlas launcher blasts off from Cape Canaveral on February 20, 1962, carrying the Friendship 7 space vehicle and John Glenn in its nose. Developed by the US Air Force, Atlas was significantly more powerful than Redstone. Glenn circled the globe three times in a flight lasting almost five hours.

